

Full Command of All Tenses and Aspects

C2 · Renan the Teacher — English Language Academy

1. BRIEF EXPLANATION

At C2, tense and aspect choices become a stylistic and rhetorical tool, not just a way to place events in time. Mastery involves subtle contrasts and deliberate shifts.

- a) Habitual past in narrative — "used to" and "would" both describe repeated past actions, but "would" cannot describe past states (be, have, know, like) and is often preferred in literary narration for its rhythm.

Every summer, we would drive to the coast and would stay in my aunt's cottage.
(not: we would have a cottage — states need "used to" or simple past: we used to have / had a cottage)

- b) Iterative and habitual aspect — the present/past continuous with "always/constantly/forever" expresses a repeated, often irritating or characteristic, action, adding emotional color beyond a neutral simple tense.

She's always leaving her keys somewhere. (mild irritation/characteristic trait) vs.
She always leaves her keys somewhere. (a neutral fact)

- c) Tense-shifting for rhetorical effect — skilled writers and speakers deliberately break "expected" tense sequencing:
 - - Historic present: switching to the present tense mid-narrative to make a past event feel vivid and immediate. "So I'm standing there, and suddenly the phone rings."
 - - Future framed as inevitable/already decided: present continuous or simple present for scheduled/fated future events, adding certainty. "The results are announced next week." / "By this time next year, she retires."
 - - Past perfect for retrospective narrative distance, even beyond its normal "earlier action" function, to create a reflective, looking-back tone in memoir-style writing.

Precision here comes from choosing aspect (simple / continuous / perfect / perfect continuous) to signal not just when, but how the speaker frames an event — as a fact, a process, a completed result, or an ongoing/repeated experience.

2. EXAMPLES

- 1. Every winter, we would gather around the fire and tell stories until midnight.
- 2. He's always interrupting people — it's one of his more irritating habits.
- 3. So I'm walking down the street, minding my own business, when this car suddenly stops right in front of me.
- 4. By the time she turns thirty, she will have already published three novels.
- 5. The committee meets again on Thursday to finalize the budget.

- 6. I had lived in six countries by the time I turned twenty-five.
- 7. She used to hate coffee, but now she can't start her day without it.
- 8. He's forever losing his phone somewhere in the house.
- 9. Looking back, I had never really understood what my father sacrificed for us.
- 10. The train departs at platform four in ten minutes.
- 11. They had been arguing for hours before either of them said anything productive.
- 12. I'll have finished the report by the time you're back from lunch.

3. COMMON MISTAKES

- 1. Incorrect: When I was a child, I would have a dog named Max.

Correct: When I was a child, I used to have / had a dog named Max.

Why: "Would" cannot describe a past state (have, be, own, like) — only repeated actions.

- 2. Incorrect: She always is losing her umbrella.

Correct: She's always losing her umbrella.

Why: With "always" for emphasis/irritation, use the continuous form and place "always" between the auxiliary and the main verb.

- 3. Incorrect: Yesterday, I am walking home when I see an old friend.

Correct: Yesterday, I was walking home when I saw an old friend. (or, for stylistic historic present, keep the whole narrative consistently in the present: I'm walking home when I see an old friend.)

Why: Don't mix a past time marker ("yesterday") with the historic present without full commitment to the technique — it must be applied consistently, not just to one verb.

- 4. Incorrect: By next year, she will finish her degree.

Correct: By next year, she will have finished her degree.

Why: For a completed action by a future point, the future perfect is required, not the simple future.

- 5. Incorrect: I had never understand what he meant until years later.

Correct: I had never understood what he meant until years later.

Why: The past perfect requires the past participle ("understood"), not the base form.

4. EXERCISES

- A. Gap-fill (choose the correct tense/aspect)

- 1. Every Sunday, my grandfather ____ (take) us fishing at dawn.
- 2. He's ____ (always/complain) about the weather, no matter what it's like.
- 3. By the time the film starts, we ____ (already/eat) dinner.
- 4. So there I ____ (stand), completely frozen, when the alarm goes off.
- 5. The conference ____ (begin) at nine sharp tomorrow, according to the schedule.
- 6. She ____ (live) in Paris for a decade before she finally moved back home.
- 7. As a teenager, I ____ (spend/would) hours reading in my room. (identify if "would" fits — rewrite if not)
- 8. By the end of this year, they ____ (be) married for twenty years.
- 9. He ____ (constantly/change) his mind, which drives the whole team crazy.
- 10. Looking back now, I ____ (never/realize) how young we all were.
- B. Rewrite / Transformation (rewrite to add the requested nuance)
- 1. My uncle told stories every evening. (rewrite with "would" for habitual past narrative)
- 2. He interrupts people. It's really annoying. (rewrite as one sentence with continuous + "always," showing irritation)
- 3. The exam finishes at noon. (rewrite as a scheduled future event using present continuous)
- 4. I finished the project before the deadline arrived. (rewrite using future perfect, imagining you're speaking before the deadline)
- 5. Describe a past event as if it's happening now, for dramatic effect: "I opened the door and saw a stranger standing there." (rewrite in the historic present)
- C. Error Correction
- 1. When I was young, I would live in a small village.
- 2. She always is checking her phone during meetings.
- 3. Tomorrow at this time, I will finish the marathon.
- 4. I had never saw such a beautiful sunset before that trip.
- 5. By 2030, this company will produce twice as much as it does now, they predict. (identify tense issue and fix)
- 6. He's constantly forgets where he left his keys.
- D. Guided Production
- 1. Write two or three sentences narrating a childhood memory using "would" for habitual past actions.
- 2. Write one sentence using present continuous + "always/constantly/forever" to describe an irritating habit of someone you know.
- 3. Write one sentence using the historic present to make a short anecdote feel vivid.
- 4. Write one sentence using the future perfect to describe something that will be completed by a specific future point.

5. ANSWER KEY

- A. Gap-fill
- 1. would take / used to take
- 2. always complaining
- 3. will already have eaten
- 4. am standing / 'm standing
- 5. begins
- 6. had lived

- 7. would spend (fits, since "spend hours reading" is a repeated action, not a state)
- 8. will have been
- 9. constantly changing / is constantly changing
- 10. had never realized
- B. Rewrite / Transformation
- 1. My uncle would tell stories every evening.
- 2. He's always interrupting people — it's really annoying.
- 3. The exam is finishing at noon. (more natural as scheduled event: "The exam finishes at noon" also acceptable; continuous emphasizes the fixed arrangement)
- 4. I will have finished the project before the deadline arrives.
- 5. I open the door and see a stranger standing there.
- C. Error Correction
- 1. When I was young, I lived / used to live in a small village.
- 2. She's always checking her phone during meetings.
- 3. Tomorrow at this time, I will be finishing / will have finished the marathon. (depending on intended meaning: in progress vs completed)
- 4. I had never seen such a beautiful sunset before that trip.
- 5. By 2030, this company will be producing twice as much as it does now, they predict. (or "will produce" if treated as a simple prediction — "will be producing" better shows an ongoing state at that future point)
- 6. He's constantly forgetting where he left his keys.
- D. Guided Production (sample answers)
- 1. Every August, my grandparents would take the whole family to the lake. We would swim all morning and would fall asleep on the porch by nine.
- 2. My roommate is forever leaving dirty dishes in the sink.
- 3. So I'm sitting in the waiting room, completely calm, and then they call my name three hours early.
- 4. By the time you land, I will have already picked up the keys to the apartment.